



◀ IRON WORKING

To extract iron, its ore had to be heated to a high temperature in a charcoal furnace known as a forge. The impurities were beaten out, then the iron was heated to make it malleable (easy to bend), and hammered into shape.

Iron being beaten in a furnace, shown in a detail from an ancient Greek vase

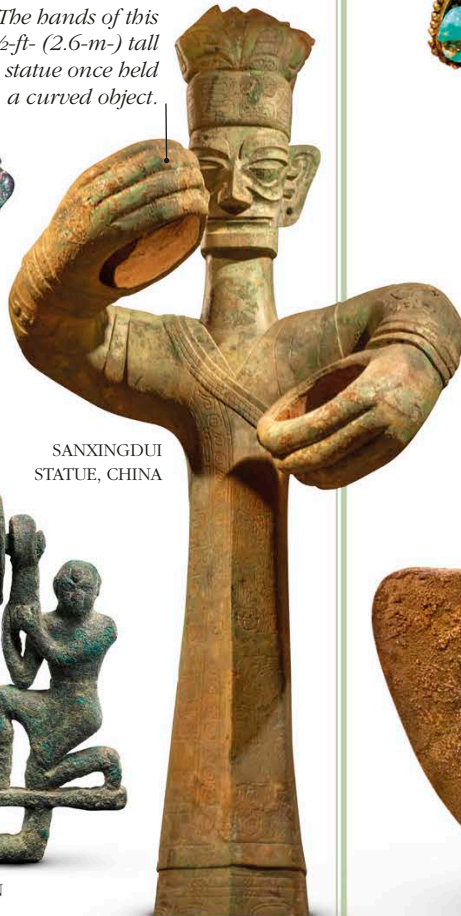
BRONZE SCULPTURES

As skills improved, metalworkers made increasingly elaborate artifacts. Bronze, cast in molds, became the most popular metal for sculptures and figurines, which often depicted people, gods, or animals. The Mesopotamian roller below would have been used to make textiles.



GREEK LYRE PLAYER

The hands of this 8½-ft- (2.6-m-) tall statue once held a curved object.



SANXINGDUI STATUE, CHINA



MESOPOTAMIAN ROLLER



Turquoise inlay

◀ AMERICAN METALLURGY

In the Americas, before the arrival of Italian explorer Christopher Columbus, people never learned to use the harder metals. They were, however, skilled at working with gold, silver, and copper, which they used to make religious objects and royal jewelry. In Peru, gold was sacred and known as the "sweat of the sun."

Ceremonial knife from the Sican culture from modern-day Peru